

From Manager to *Director*.

Ten steps, two to five years, written for the UK firm. The jump is not a harder version of your current job — it is a **change of category**. Managers are paid to deliver; Directors are paid to originate and to own a number. Everything below is built around that discontinuity and the UK calendar that gates it.

WHERE THE HEADROOM IS

UK REVENUE GROWTH BY SERVICE LINE · FY25



UK fee income £3.78bn, +2% overall (FY25, to 27 June 2025). By sector, Consumer & Health grew 9% and Financial Services 5%. A Director seat is funded out of a growing P&L — FY26 lands in October.

Manager

YOU ARE HERE

>

Senior Manager

THE WALL · 2-4 YRS

>

Director

THE TARGET

>

Associate Partner

>

Partner

ELECTED

THE UK CLOCK / FINANCIAL YEAR RUNS 1 JULY - 30 JUNE / PROMOTIONS EFFECTIVE 1 JULY

Jul - Dec

Bank the evidence

Nothing counts that isn't already done and attributed.

Jan - Mar

Roundtables, nominations

Decided here, from what existed by Christmas.

Apr - Jun

Outcomes land

You hear the result; the case closed months ago.

1 July

Effective

Grade changes; pay follows roughly three months later.

1 DECLARE

Say it out loud, in writing, this cycle

Ambition kept private does not exist. Put **Director** in your LEAD goals and say it to your counsellor before 1 July — then ask the question most people avoid: **what exactly is missing?** A pipeline you are not named in never considers you.

Ask for the gap list. Get it in writing.

2 NARROW

Own one intersection, not five

Pick a **sector × capability** tight enough that you are the first call — not "data", but "AI assurance for insurers". Directors are bought, not applied for: the market has to ask for you by name. Breadth cannot be sold; depth can.

Target: top-3 recognised name in one niche

3 SPONSOR

Recruit the person who spends capital on you

A mentor advises you; a **sponsor argues for you in rooms you will never enter** — roughly 23% better odds. You sit in the UK *and* global head office, so the deciders are in your building, alongside 8,000 others. Proximity pays only if they can name what you did.

1 sponsor + 3-5 partners who can cite your numbers

4 MIX

Move from 80/20 delivery to 60/40 by year two

Being superb at delivery is the **most common way to get trapped in it**. The firm has every incentive to keep you billing, and nobody will hand you origination time. Block it like a client meeting, and defend it like one.

~2 days a week on origination by end of Y2

5 REVENUE

Get a number with your name on it

Directors are judged on **owned revenue and pipeline**, not effort. Move from "I delivered on that account" to "that account is mine", and track it monthly. Director bands sit near ~\$1.75m managed, with a matching cross-sell target.

Own the P&L of one account or capability

6 CROSS-SELL

Bring the whole firm — unless you are in Audit

Outside Assurance, pulling Tax, SaT and Consulting into your accounts *is* the Director test. Inside it, **UK operational separation inverts this**: the ring-fenced audit practice takes no fee for introductions, and pay turns above all on **audit quality**. Know which currency you are paid in.

Advisory: 3+ service lines · Audit: quality + tenders

7 BENCH

Build the person who replaces you

You cannot be promoted out of a seat **nobody else can fill**. Grow two Managers who can run delivery without you, and let partners watch them do it. Successor risk is a quiet reason strong cases get deferred a year.

2 named successors, proven on live engagements

8 CASE

Write the business case three years early

Submission windows are often a **single week** — the case is retrieved then, not written. Keep a live one-pager led by attribution: "Led the pricing review that recovered £4.2m", never "was involved in". Committees credit you less than you assume.

Refresh quarterly, before every counsellor conversation

9 HEADROOM

Go where the UK firm is actually growing

The firm must believe **the seat pays for itself**. The chart above is that argument: Strategy & Transactions ran +10% last year while Consulting fell 6% and shed ~150 senior roles. Seats are funded out of growth, not need.

Aim at a line that grew, not one that cut

10 DEADLINE

Set a decision date and honour it

Give it **two full cycles** once you are formally in the pipeline. If you are not nominated, not sponsored, and the answer never becomes specific, that is the answer. A lateral at the next grade resets both cases at once.

Hard review point: two cycles, then decide

GATE 1 — PERSONAL CASE

Can you do the job? Delivery excellence, ratings, leadership, a visible niche. Necessary, and on its own never sufficient.

GATE 2 — BUSINESS CASE

Does the seat pay for itself? Owned revenue, pipeline, cross-sell, a market with funded headroom.

GATE 3 — POLITICAL CASE

Who argues for you in the room? One sponsor with capital, several partners who can quote your numbers.

Scale of the prize. £3.78bn of UK fee income in FY25, 59 new equity partners admitted, an average £787k distributed per partner. **The clock:** two to four years a grade — compressing it means over-delivering on gates 2 and 3 before anyone asks. **The failure mode is never effort:** it is a brilliant deliverer with no book, no sponsor and no niche, waiting to be noticed by a process that does not work that way.

SOURCES · EY UK FY25 results & partner disclosures · FRC operational-separation principles · Big 4 partner-promotion research (Townsend) · Hewlett, sponsorship effect · practitioner reporting on Big 4 managed-revenue targets